

SATURDAY SEPTEMBER 19 2015
CHARLOTTEOBSERVER.COM

The Charlotte Observer

Insight

GOING DEEPER INTO THE

FROM PAGE 13A

PARKS AND REC

As for the outside, "we're going to relocate some of the trees and change landscaping a bit," Jones said.

The center has been closed since June, but officials plan it to reopen next April, just in time to host the SwimMAC Arena Pro Swim Series in May.

● Latta Nature Preserve improvements

The lowdown: Currently in the planning and design development phase, the county and Carolina Raptor Center are creating a new nature center at the Latta Nature Preserve in Huntersville that will include updated offices, a reception space and gift shops, Jones said.

The new center will replace the current, older one, and the raptor center will maintain its separate hospital, he said. Construction on a \$100,000 kayak launch accessible from the nature preserve is already finished.

● Queens University Tennis Center

The lowdown: Ground will break this fall on the tennis center at the Queens Sports Complex at the Marion Diehl Recreation Center on Tyvola Road. Once finished, the center will boast 13 tennis courts, a championship court, restrooms and an adjacent facility with

meeting space and locker rooms for tennis, track and field and field hockey.

Once Queens builds the infrastructure for the courts and installs the conduit for utilities and water, the county will step in to install lighting and perform surface treatment on the courts to make the material sturdy and flexible, Jones said.

A Queens University of Charlotte spokeswoman said the school aims to make the courts available to the public next fall, and the entire tennis center open by fall 2017.

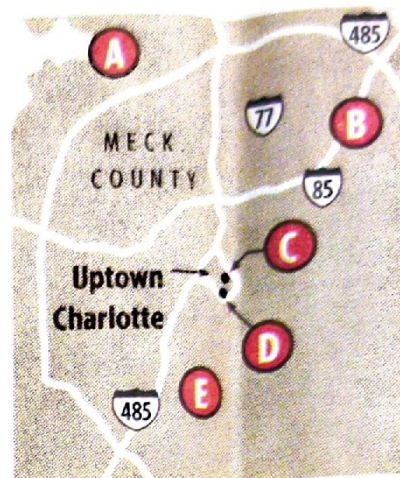
● Barton Creek Greenway

The lowdown: This greenway will connect J.W. Clay Boulevard and Mallard Creek Greenway in University City, giving the neighborhoods between those areas access to 9 miles of an existing greenway trail. Right now, engineers are conducting soil boring tests after finding evidence of a layer of rock near the trail's surface.

Jones said the county plans to submit the project for construction bids this fall and hopes to start construction on the greenway in February.

Where to find them

Now enjoying a renewed level of financial stability post-recession, Mecklenburg County is hoping to fulfill on promises it made to voters years ago for new parks and recreation projects. Here are five big ones:



A New nature center at Latta Nature Preserve

- **Cost:** \$7.8 million
- **Planned debut:** Dec. 2017 (est.)
- **Where:** 6211 Sample Road, Huntersville

B Barton Creek Greenway

- **Cost:** \$1.6 million
- **Planned debut:** July 2016 (est.)
- **Where:** Between J.W. Clay Boulevard and Mallard Creek Greenway in University City area.

C First Ward Park

- **Cost:** \$11.3 million
- **Planned debut:** Nov. 2015 (est.)
- **Where:** Between ImaginOn children's library on Seventh Street & UNCC's Center City campus on Ninth Street.

D Mecklenburg County Aquatic Center

- **Cost:** \$9.3 million
- **Planned debut:** April 2016 (est.)
- **Where:** 800 E. Martin Luther King Jr. Blvd.

Queens University